

Introduction

Last week you watched a short video that talked about the [Roles and Responsibilities of Elected Officials](#) [6:34]. It emphasized the importance of a good and respectful relationship between the mayor, councillors, and staff.

We will continue our look at the structures and machinery of local government this week with a focus on the municipal administration (or public service) and municipal agencies, boards, and commissions (or special purpose bodies). Both connect in key ways with the political governance machinery of municipalities that was discussed last week.

The module will also look at municipal accountability officers, who are part of the machinery of government but independent of the municipal administration.

Topics and Learning Objectives

Topics

- Municipal administration models and influence
- Accountability structures and officers
- Agencies, boards, and commissions

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

- Identify the different municipal administrative structures
- Assess the nature of the relationship between elected representatives and staff
- Explain municipal accountability processes and identify key accountability roles
- Identify the implications for municipal decision-making and accountability of municipal, inter-municipal, and provincially established municipal agencies, boards, and commissions

Readings

Reading

Please Note: You can access all non-textbook readings through the One-Stop Course Readings in the Table of Contents in your D2L Brightspace course.

Required

1. Lucas, J. (2013). *Hidden in plain view: Local agencies, boards, and commissions in Canada*. Institute on Municipal Finance & Governance, Munk School of Global Affairs, University of Toronto.
2. CAMA. (2023, March). The role and significance of the Chief Administrative Officer Position in Canadian Municipal government. A CAMA “white paper” on Ontario’s strong mayor legislation and the pivotal role of the CAO in providing good governance. Canadian Association of Municipal Administrators.

The Bureaucracy

The **municipal administration** is the second component in the machinery of local government. Often referred to as the “bureaucracy,” this group includes all municipal staff and senior officials who are employed by the municipality.

Kernaghan and Siegel define **bureaucracy** as “a form of organization characterized by hierarchical structure, unity of command, hiring and promotion by merit, and specialization of labour” (1995, 679). The term “bureaucracy” can sometimes have a negative connotation that brings to mind images about inefficient public sector employees. It is, however, based on sound principles of public administration and was introduced in an effort to establish fair and consistent decision-making and service and an emphasis on effectiveness.

As Tindal et al. (2017) note, there have traditionally been requirements for the establishment of certain **statutory officers** of the municipality such as treasurer, clerk, or solicitor (2017). While this has been changing over time and there is significant variation across the country, municipalities tend to have some designated, statutory positions.

Models of Municipal Administration

Municipalities are organized based on **five** basic models of municipal administration:

1. the departmental model,
2. the commissioner or board of management model,
3. the council-manager model,
4. the (modified) manager model, and
5. the city manager model.

Tab Panels (expanded):

Tab: Early Models

Departmental and Board of Management

The relationship between council, the administration, and special purpose bodies has evolved over time. The first period of development was from WWII to the 1970s and was characterized by a high degree of integration between municipal councils and the administration. The departmental model and board of management system were prevalent. Special purpose bodies were generally unquestioned.

Departmental Model

The **departmental model** was prominent in Canadian municipalities until the mid-1970s. It separated municipal functions and assigned responsibility for a function to an administrative department head. All department heads reported directly to the municipal council, often through a standing committee. Department heads were equal, and each had an independent relationship with the municipal council. Not surprisingly, the model had the tendency to promote the development of bureaucratic empires within departments. Coordination between departments was weak and there was little incentive to integrate policies or services.

Commissioner or Board of Management Model

The **commissioner** or **board of management model** assigns responsibility for the management of the municipality's affairs to a group or board rather than a single city manager. Each commissioner would have responsibility for a group of services – for example, all hard services, soft services, corporate administrative services, etc. The group of commissioners, led by the chief administrative officer (CAO) as a first among equals, would meet regularly to plan and coordinate the operations and management of the municipality. In the past, the mayor may have participated on the board of commissioners or board of management, providing a political-administrative link.

Tab: 1970s Onward

Shifting Models of Administration from the 1970s Onward

By the mid-1970s and into the 1980s there was a shift to CAO and city manager models in larger cities. This changed the relationship between senior staff and elected representatives and between departments, which were under pressure to become more administratively integrated and work horizontally across boundaries. In some areas, there was a questioning of the role of special purpose bodies. The 1990s were a time of re-examination in local government that included looking at who does what, examining how it is done, as well as measuring and reorganizing in an effort to find cost savings and efficiencies.

Both of these periods of change were influenced by business approaches and principles. There was a sense that governments in general, and local government in particular, were getting too large, were inefficient in delivering services, and had weak internal controls. Tindal et al. (2017) discuss the influence of new public management (NPM) in local government in Canada and its influence on the organization of local governments. The emphasis on performance and accountability sets these NPM reforms apart from earlier structural changes, and the use of special purpose bodies and “board of management” and “city manager” terminology reinforce the desire for more control over government.

Municipalities have continued to adapt to ongoing fiscal, downloading, and political pressures by restructuring and refocusing. In general, there has been a reduction in the number of senior officials in municipalities and an emphasis on integration and horizontal linkages within program areas. Municipal administrations are becoming more dynamic, and new approaches to managing issues are being implemented, including service clusters and project teams that involve internal and external stakeholders.

Council-Manager Model

The **council-manager model**, popular in the U.S., shifted power from department heads to a strong, central city manager (also called CAO). In this model, the city manager is the only point of contact for the administration with the elected council. Councils in the city-manager system do not usually have standing committees and there is little/no interaction between senior staff and councillors. The manager has authority to hire and fire senior staff and exercises strong control over the administration. The city manager also has significant influence over the council, which does not generally have strong operational or program knowledge. While the city manager or CAO is very powerful, they are also very vulnerable, especially in situations of conflict. Sancton (2015) notes that there is no Canadian municipality where the full city manager/CAO model has been implemented. Many municipalities were reluctant to move to the city manager model because of a fear that the city manager position would be too powerful – both in the internal administrative side of the organization and politically in terms of challenges and rivalries with the mayor and members of council.

However, Canadian municipalities faced pressures for greater professionalization and a stronger non-political role in managing the municipality. Thus, a **modified manager model** has become popular. A professional city manager would oversee all administrative activities and departmental functions and report to the municipal council. While the

department heads report to the city manager, they also connect with the council through a standing committee structure and have accountability to council through that committee. Council is responsible for hiring the manager and is generally involved in some way in the appointment of senior staff.

Chief Administrative Officer Model

The **chief administrative officer model** is a weak or modified form of the city manager model. The CAO would have responsibility for all the administrative areas in the municipality, including finance, clerks, communications, human resources, and legal, but generally, they did not have responsibility for the operating departments that provide services directly to the public. In this model, these departments, such as parks and recreation, transportation, and social services, would be run by a department head or commissioner who would report directly to the municipal council. The CAO would not have responsibility or authority for the major services provided by the municipality.

City Manager Model

In the **city manager model**, the most senior municipal staff position is the city manager who has responsibility for all municipal administration and service delivery. The city manager reports directly to council. Many authors, including the authors of the course textbook, will use “city manager” and “chief administrative officer” interchangeably. It is important to note that there was and still remains a difference in the roles and scope of authority in some municipalities.

Preferred Administration Model Today

Most municipalities use some form of the city manager or chief administrative officer. This “super-bureaucrat” plays a key role in the municipal administration and is usually selected and appointed under contract by the municipal council.

Video

Listen to the [Mayor of Fort St John and the CAO](#) [2:40] reflect on the upcoming retirement of the incumbent and what the municipality is looking for in its recruitment for a new CAO.

Depending on the individual, they may have different types of relationships with the senior staff/department heads. Plunkett (as referenced in Tindal et al., 2017, 257) describes three types of relationships:

- **Passive** – the city manager plays a passive role, coordinating and supporting department heads
- **Dominant** – the manager plays a dominant role, managing and controlling operations and budgets and policy and program recommendations to council
- **Active** – active relationships are the third type of relationship and are the most common. The city manager will be actively involved with departments in working toward shared priorities and managing the relationship with council.

The city manager or CAO has a tough job navigating between the political and administrative and faces high expectations. As described by Canadian CAOs:

“The CAO is the conduit between governance and employees – having that sensibility around making the politics work and the business work.” (StrategyCorp, 2019, 53)

“Being a CAO is about knowing how to live in the political world while keeping one foot firmly in the administrative world.” (StrategyCorp, 2018, 36)

Municipal issues are complex and interconnected, and there is constant pressure for both innovation and efficiency. Municipalities provide services directly, but they also must manage services that are contracted out or delivered through private-public partnerships or other partnership arrangements. The municipal environment is dynamic because there are multiple stakeholders with competing interests, including the public, property owners (and taxpayers), businesses, developers, nonprofits and charities, the province or territory, and the federal government. Expectations are high.

Activity

Have a look at the municipal organization charts listed below and/or look at municipalities you are familiar with, have visited, or have lived in, and look for their organization chart on their website. It can sometimes be difficult to find – you may need to look under city services, city hall, or a similar broad heading.

Here are a handful to get you started:

- [Management structure](#) – Kamloops, British Columbia is a city of about 100,000 people. It is part of the Thompson-Nicola Regional District.
- [Organization chart](#) – City of Greater Sudbury, Ontario has 161,000 people.
- [Corporate organization chart](#) – City of Brampton in Peel Region has a population of over 600,000 people.
- [Organization chart](#) – City of Toronto, population of more than 2.7 million people.

Reflection

1. What do the charts tell you about the structure of the administration?
2. Which model best describes each of the municipal structures?
3. Based on your knowledge of the municipality and the council, do you think that the model is a good fit?

Bureaucratic Influence

Bureaucrats are expected to be unbiased, objective, and nonpartisan. Nonetheless, by virtue of their position, expertise, and experience, they exert varying degrees of influence on what municipal government does and how it is done. Senior officials have the most significant influence. While elected members of council vote on policies and programs, the senior bureaucrat plays a critical role in advising the members and implementing their decisions. Senior municipal staff submit reports to the standing committees (and sometimes directly to council) about issues, programs, funding, or new policies. Sometimes they are asked by these committees or by council to prepare a report on an issue; other times, they take the initiative and propose a new program or policy or a change to an existing policy. They answer questions, provide information at the committee meeting, and explain why they feel the item should be approved. Once a decision has been made, they are responsible for implementing the decision. There is usually some discretion involved in implementation or policy enforcement, and the senior staff can influence the implementation.

Elected councillors rely heavily on senior staff. Councillors are often part-time and rarely have the background, education, or experience in the service areas. They are responsible for a wide range of services – they cannot be experts in all the service areas – and they come to rely on the knowledgeable and experienced senior staff for advice and direction. Often senior staff have an opinion or perspective on the issue, and their advice is influenced by their staff’s perspective on the issue.

The non-parliamentary nature of council politics reinforces the influence of the bureaucracy. Political parties usually develop position statements on key policy issues – these statements guide the politicians while in office. When they are elected, their platform provides guidance to the bureaucrats concerning priorities and policy directions. As previously discussed, there is no formal party politics at the municipal level, and the municipal election does not create a clear mandate for staff to follow.

This discussion is not meant to suggest that senior bureaucrats “run the show” at municipal council. Rather, it is to illustrate their influence on the machinery of local government and decision-making processes.

Accountability Structures and Officers

Municipalities may also include one or more independent accountability officers. These roles have been added by municipal councils over the last 20 years as independent officers reporting directly to council. While these officers are employees of the municipality, they are not part of the bureaucracy or administration. They instead focus on distinct functions related to accountability – integrity; ethics; complaints; lobbying; stewardship of resources; and open, accessible decision-making.

A municipal government must act in the best interest of its community members. Municipal representatives, mayors, and councillors are elected by voters and are accountable and responsive to them. But elections are every four years, and accountability is muddled by factors such as poor memory; lack of information; fragmented service and funding structures and program partnerships; and contracting out. We will explore issues of municipal accountability later in the Module 10 discussion of municipal relationships with the public.

In addition to accountability through elections, some provinces and territories have provided the option in provincial municipal acts for municipalities to pass bylaws to add formal accountability functions to their municipality. For example, the 2006 *Ontario Municipal Act* gave municipalities the authority to appoint accountability officers. In other cases, provinces have required municipalities to add or arrange for specific accountability functions.

Some of the specific accountability functions are described in the following tabs and include:

Tab Panels (expanded):

Tab: Integrity Commissioner

Integrity commissioners are concerned with the ethical behaviour of elected councillors and the mayor, administer the code of conduct, and provide advice to members of council about potential conflict of interest or ethical issues.

Integrity commissioners have authority over municipal councils and municipal agencies, boards, and commissions.

Did You Know?

- Toronto created the first full-time municipal integrity commissioner in 2004 following the Bellamy Inquiry into a computer leasing scandal, which is discussed in the readings for this week.
- Calgary appointed an integrity commissioner in 2016 with dual integrity and ethics advisory responsibility.

Tab: Municipal Ombudsman

A **municipal ombudsman** is an independent officer who reviews actions and decisions taken by municipal councils and their agencies, boards, and commissions. Ombudsman functions have authority to investigate complaints from the public and to initiate investigations when they feel they are warranted. The exceptions are policy decisions and financial matters (which are the responsibility of the auditor general). The City of Montreal established an ombudsman in 2002.

Ontario municipalities can establish their own independent officers or choose to be covered by the Ontario ombudsman. The Ontario ombudsman has authority to review decisions of municipal ombudspersons, except for those of the Toronto officer. Halifax, Winnipeg, and Vancouver are required to have ombudsman functions by their respective provincial legislation.

Tab: Auditor General

A **municipal auditor general** is different from the internally focused municipal auditor that is part of the municipal administration and reports through a committee of council. The independent auditor general reports directly to council and helps municipal councils be accountable for the stewardship of public funds and resources.

Toronto is the only Ontario municipality required, in the 2006 *City of Toronto Act*, to have an independent auditor general. Some municipalities have moved to integrate the auditor general and internal audit functions: Winnipeg changed the responsibilities for their auditor general to include internal audit functions in 2009 as have Hamilton, Calgary, and Edmonton.

British Columbia appointed a provincial auditor general in 2012 to provide the independent review function for municipalities in that province.

Tab: Lobbyist Registrar/Registration

A lobbyist registration system requires lobbyists to register with the municipality and to comply with municipal rules, processes, and codes of conduct. Lobbyists generally must register each interaction with municipal representatives, identifying who they lobbied and why.

The cities of Toronto and Hamilton have independent **lobbyist registrars** with responsibility for administering the process. When it was set up, Toronto's lobbyist registration was voluntary, but it was subsequently changed to mandatory. The City of Ottawa has combined the integrity commissioner and lobbyist registrar function. The City of Winnipeg originally established an integrity commissioner but expanded the role to include lobbyist registrar before the first official was appointed in early 2017.

Tab: Closed Meeting Investigator

Municipal acts use terms like "open," "transparent," and "accountable" to describe municipal decision-making processes. This legislation sets out strict parameters for municipalities to meet in camera in meetings that are closed to the public. The **closed meeting investigator** reviews municipalities to ensure that they are functioning in accordance with the closed meeting rules.

The British Columbia provincial ombudsman investigates closed municipal meetings; in Ontario, the provincial ombudsman does the same, except for Toronto and Ottawa, which have independent closed meeting investigators.

Accountability officers provide advice and make recommendations to municipal councils, who, in turn, have the authority to make decisions on the issues and impose any penalties or sanctions. “Accountability officers have limited formal authority, but considerable power to influence public opinion” (Sancton, 2017, 1). Their independence and public reports provide valuable information to municipal voters and community members.

Pause and Reflect

Examine your municipalities website. Does it talk about accountability to the community and voters? Does the municipality have accountability officers? If not, does it provide information for community members about how to access provincial officers who provide oversight on municipal decisions and actions? Is the information easy to find and clearly communicated?

Do a bit more digging to learn if your municipality has had issues related to accountability. If so, what role did accountability officers play in investigating and resolving the issue?

What Are Special Purpose Bodies and What Do They Do?

In addition to municipalities, there are a number of other decision-making service delivery bodies at the municipal level known as **special purpose bodies** or **agencies, boards, and commissions** (ABCs) that are part of local government. Tindal et al. (2017, 8) estimate that there are about 8,000 municipal special purpose bodies in Canada that control significant resources.

[I]n many Canadian cities, more than a third of the city’s operating budget is handed over to special-purpose bodies every year. (Lucas, 2013, 2)

Examples include transit commissions, police services boards, hydro commissions, heritage boards, and conservation authorities.

Key Point

Special purpose bodies are assigned specific responsibility for a purpose or mandate; their role and powers vary depending on their area of focus. These bodies differ greatly in their role and membership. Some have service delivery responsibility while others have service delivery and policy-making powers. Special purpose bodies generally have jurisdictional boundaries that reflect municipal boundaries or the boundaries of a group of municipalities.

They have a degree of autonomy from the municipal government and can be created by municipal bylaw or imposed by a province or territory through legislation.

Agencies, boards, and commissions are controlled by independent boards that include elected municipal representatives, municipal appointees, provincial appointees, or a mix of each. Funding arrangements also vary – they can’t impose taxes and often impose user charges. They may receive significant funding from the municipal government or provincial grants. In

some cases the municipality will have authority to approve the agency, board, or commission budget because it is integrated into the municipal budget; in other cases it can either approve or reject (but not adjust) the budget; and in other cases, it has no control over the budget.

Why Do We Have Special Purpose Bodies?

During the early reform phases (discussed in Module 2), provinces deliberately established municipal special purpose bodies to transfer power away from the municipalities to bodies that were composed of provincial appointees (e.g., the Ontario Railway and Municipal Board established in 1906). This served to undermine local democracy by taking power from locally elected representatives and giving it to provincially appointed individuals.

In 1977, John Robarts, previous premier of Ontario, headed up a royal commission reviewing the municipal government in the city of Toronto's two-tier metro system. Robarts wrote: "The province exercises control over many local services by delegating the responsibility for them not to councils but to special purpose bodies" and further that "they appear to be sub-units of provincial administration rather than units of local government administration" (Ontario, 1977, 96 and 99). This tension continues with each appointment to a provincially designated municipal special purpose body. Provincially established special purpose bodies still serve to disperse decision-making about municipal services and weaken municipal councils.

Municipalities have established special purpose bodies, most recently as part of new public management initiatives to move municipalities out of the business of doing and position them as policy makers, steering the municipality. Municipalities established new corporations and delegated responsibility to them for programs, and they established new bodies with other municipalities to manage joint programs.

Municipal Special Purpose Bodies

Municipal special purpose bodies are established by municipalities to serve municipal interests. Many of these organizations are formally incorporated, like the Toronto Transit Commission (TTC), Toronto Community Housing, and the Toronto Zoo. The municipality is the sole shareholder of the organization and sets the terms, conditions, and mandate for the special purpose body.

Ontario municipalities have a number of other municipal bodies, established in response to provincial legislation and requirements, that vary in the level of control and influence in the municipality. For example, school boards are directly funded by and accountable to the Ontario government, yet school board representatives are directly elected in municipal elections. Police service boards and public health boards include some municipally elected representatives and appointed citizen members. Police boards also include provincially appointed members.

Inter-municipal Agencies, Boards, or Commissions

Sometimes municipalities work together to form organizations like the [Association of Municipalities of Ontario](#) (AMO), the [Association of Manitoba Municipalities](#) (AMM), or the [Federation of Municipalities of Canada](#) (FCM). Alternatively, they may collaborate with municipal neighbours by establishing an agency to address issues of joint concern.

Provincially Established Municipal Special Purpose Bodies

Many special purpose bodies are mandated by the province or territory. This means that there is legislation that assigns responsibility for the service to an agency, board, or commission established by the province or territory.

Here are three Ontario-based examples to illustrate different types of provincially established municipal special purpose bodies.

Tab Panels (expanded):

Tab: Police Services Boards – Ontario

In Ontario, the *Police Services Act* requires the establishment of a police services board in every municipality that has a police force. The legislation describes the role, membership, and appointment of local police services boards. Boards of three, five, or seven members are required, depending on population size. The police services board in Toronto includes the mayor, two councillors, three provincial appointees, and one citizen appointee. The police chief is accountable to the board, and the board is accountable to the community as well as to the Ontario Civilian Commission on Police Services.

In 2019, the City of Toronto estimated that the average property owner, with a property tax of \$3,020, would contribute \$703.21 toward the cost of policing (Toronto, 2019). Even though the City of Toronto has to raise the money to pay for policing through the property tax, they do not direct the police force or set policing policy, with three of seven votes on the police services board.

Tab: Metrolinx

Metrolinx is a provincial agency that was originally established as the Greater Toronto Transit Authority (GTTA) and included members from municipal councils in the Greater Toronto area. The GTTA was changed to Metrolinx in 2006 and given responsibility for regional transportation planning, developing a unified regional transit fare system, procurement, and duties including development and construction related to the regional transportation system.

Metrolinx's 15-member board of directors is appointed by the Lieutenant Governor of Ontario on behalf of Ontario. There are no elected members of council from any of the municipalities in the Metrolinx catchment area on the board of directors, even though some of them operate municipal transit programs.

The provincial agency makes decisions that have implications for municipal transit operators. For example, Metrolinx is rolling out a common electronic payment system, called Presto, across the partner transit systems. Each transit operator is concerned about a negative impact of this system on their operations. The TTC, Toronto's transit provider, published the results of a study that the TTC had ["lost revenues" of about \\$4.2 M as a result](#) of the Toronto roll-out of the payment system.

In addition, Metrolinx's responsibility for transit planning and decisions about investment in new transit have implications for municipal economic development and growth. Decisions about new GO stations (a regional transit service) or frequency of transit service can influence the shape of municipalities. Metrolinx provides an example of a provincially established ABC that integrates and plans for regions (including municipalities) without decision-making involvement of the elected officials from those municipalities.

Tab: Ontario Municipal Board

You have read about the Ontario Municipal Board (OMB) in earlier modules. Other provinces have similar independent oversight bodies established to monitor and make some decisions related to municipalities. The OMB was established in 1906 as the Ontario Railway and Municipal Board to oversee the finances of municipalities and supervise the railways, which were, at the time, the main source of transport between municipalities. Eventually, the OMB gained more responsibility to adjudicate in cases of dispute related to some regulations, planning, and development. Interestingly, it has retained authority to approve municipal borrowing for capital expenditures for all Ontario municipalities!

The OMB was controversial in its role as the appeal body in the case of a dispute over a municipal decision. It was used most frequently to challenge decisions regarding zoning and planning matters, but Module 4 described how a councillor appealed to the OMB regarding the decision on Toronto ward boundaries. In 2018, Ontario replaced the

OMB by giving municipalities the authority to establish independent local planning appeal tribunals in accordance with provincial legislation. Toronto set up a [Toronto Local Planning Appeal Tribunal \(LPAT\)](#) to assume some of the functions previously provided by the OMB, including appeals on a range of planning and land matters.

In 2019, Ontario announced changes to the LPAT process – instead of referring appeals back to the municipality for further consideration if the tribunal disagreed with the municipal decision, the LPAT would have the authority to make the final and binding decision. In effect, they were given the powers of the old OMB, which led to widespread criticism of that provincial agency. This is a good example of how agencies can be used and adapted based on political interests – in this case, based on provincial interests.

Are Special Purpose Bodies Good for Local Government?

There is considerable debate whether special purpose bodies are good for local government. Supporters argue that some services, such as policing, may be too sensitive to leave in the hands of elected officials and they appreciate the mixed board structure that includes at least one community representative. Others support the focus and attention to a service area or issue given by a special purpose body and to the assignment of responsibility to appointees with expertise and knowledge of the issue area.

Municipalities have wide and broad responsibility. Assigning some of that responsibility to a special purpose agency will bring attention and clear focus to that service and, at the same time, will give municipal councils more time and energy to address their core functions. The result may be more effective and more efficient service delivery.

Critics counter that it is undemocratic to take power from elected officials who have been chosen by the public to represent them and assign it to appointed individuals with no direct accountability. Unelected special purpose bodies may not be responsive to public concerns. The existence of so many bodies can lead to confusion among residents about how local government works. Transparency in decision-making processes may vary among municipal agencies, contributing to confusion and concerns about accountability.

Similar questions of accountability can be directed to the composition of the boards. Should they include elected or appointed members or both? What about provincial boards established in municipal areas – should they include municipal representatives, either elected or appointed? Accountability is also important in funding. Municipalities contribute to many agencies, boards, and commissions but don't always have a say in how the resources are used.

Provincially established municipal agencies bring additional benefits and challenges. If the agency crosses municipal boundaries, it has potential to bring attention and leadership to a shared issue of concern. It is possible that a provincially established municipal agency will have access to provincial funds that otherwise wouldn't have been available. Moreover, in situations where there is conflict among municipalities, a provincially established municipal agency may be able to negotiate a resolution.

Provincial special purpose bodies are often seen to be a way of weakening local councils and extending provincial control into municipal issues. This happens through the establishment of the agency and in the ongoing appointment of provincial nominees to the board of the special purpose body. There is no local accountability for the actions of provincial municipal agencies – the accountability is to the province. Community members, confused by municipal agencies and the municipality, will be further confused by the existence of provincially established agencies at the municipal level. As the examples showed, there is potential for conflict and tension about political agendas and priorities and funding. Provincially established municipal agencies reduce scope for municipal decision-making autonomy – John Robarts, quoted earlier, recommended that all special purpose bodies be abolished and that responsibility for the issue areas should be given back to municipalities.

Pause and Reflect

Look again at your municipal website. Does the website identify any municipally established special purpose bodies? If so, what do they do and how do they connect with the municipality? Are there some agencies, boards, and commissions that you know about that aren't listed on the website? Why?

What about provincial special purpose bodies? Is there information on the municipal website about them? If not, is it easy to identify them and learn more?

Finally, do you think there are more advantages or disadvantages to having municipal special purpose bodies? What about provincially established municipal agencies, boards, and commissions – are you pro or con?

Summary

This module completes our look at the machinery of local government. It showed that municipal councils may be the elected decision-makers in local government, but agencies, boards, and commissions also make important decisions about key municipal services and programs. The module distinguished between municipally and provincially established special purpose bodies that are active at the municipal level and considered the implications for municipal authority and autonomy.

Staff support informed decision-making and implement directions from council – they too play an important role in shaping and influencing decisions and implementation. The different administrative models show different relationships between senior staff and municipal councils, with implications for authority and influence.

The module introduced accountability officers – senior staff appointed directly by municipal council who report directly to council. These accountability officers are independent municipal employees and are not part of the administration. Not all municipalities have these functions, but many are covered by officers providing some of the functions at the provincial or territorial level.

The machinery of local government is complex and dynamic. It changes over time based on events and actions, our understanding of local government, and the relationships between the elected representatives, the administration, and the agencies, boards, and commissions.

The assignment – Municipal Decision-Making – due at the end of this course week will give you the opportunity to further reflect on the machinery of local government.

Key Takeaways

- The municipal administration is a key element of the machinery of local government.
- The administrative models have evolved over time based on a number of pressures, including the relationship with council.
- Most municipalities follow a city manager (or CAO) model.
- The city manager plays an important leadership role in the municipality, straddling the political and administrative and juggling a range of challenging issues.
- Municipal accountability functions include integrity commissioners, municipal ombudspersons, auditor generals, lobbyist registrars, and closed meeting investigators. These may be internal to the municipality, reporting directly to council and separate from municipal administrations, or provided by the province or territory for all municipalities.
- Municipal agencies, boards, and commissions play important roles in delivering a range of local services and programs. They can be established by the municipality or by a province or territory to cover one or more municipalities.
- While there are clear benefits to special purpose bodies, there are also some important challenges related to accountability, transparency, and autonomy.

Coming Up Next

Next week we will begin the first of three modules that examine municipal relationships. Module 6 will explore intergovernmental relationships – municipal relationships with the federal, provincial, and territorial governments.

Discussions and Assignments

Week 5 Discussion

Note: There is no discussion this week to give you additional time to focus on your assignment.

However, you are encouraged to share your thoughts on this week's content in the **optional** Week 5 Discussion area.

- Were you surprised by any of the content or readings?
- What did you learn about your local municipality and its administration, accountability officers, or agencies, boards, and commissions?
- Share your thoughts and comments on one or more of the "Pause and Reflect" questions in this module.

Note: You can access the Discussion Forums & Topics from the Communications menu in your D2L course.

Please make sure that your participation in all discussion forums adheres to the Toronto Metropolitan University online etiquette guidelines listed in the Course Outline.

Assignment

- Assignment 1 is due at the end of this course week – Friday by 11:59 p.m. See the Assignments section of the Course Materials area in D2L for details.

References

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